

Lychee Grow Guide

For customers transplanting Para-life Trees air-layered / circumposed lychee trees in Jamaica

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Quick expectations - specific numbers to plan with

What to expect	Planning number
Tree type sold	Para-life Trees lychee trees are air-layered / circumposed trees. They are not seedlings, so they usually fruit sooner than seed-grown trees once well established.
Best location	Full sun, good airflow, and a spot that does not flood. Cooler hillsides or areas with a noticeable cool/dry season give the best chance of flowering in Jamaica.
Planting distance	Give about 25-30 feet from buildings, walls, large trees, and other fruit trees if you want a full canopy.
Mature size	Unpruned lychee can reach about 30-50 feet tall and 30-50 feet wide. For easy care, keep home-garden trees around 10-15 feet, or orchard trees around 12-18 feet.
Soil pH target	Aim for slightly acidic soil, about pH 5.5-6.5. Good drainage is more important than rich soil.
Water pH target	Best around pH 6.0-7.0. Avoid very alkaline or salty water if possible.
Fruiting expectation	Air-layered trees may start fruiting about 2-5 years after planting under good conditions, but lowland heat, too much nitrogen, or no cool/dry rest can delay or reduce fruiting.

Important note: Lychee can grow into a beautiful green tree but still fruit poorly if it does not get the right flowering trigger. Cool, dry rest before flowering is one of the most important conditions.

1. Choose the right location before transplanting

- Choose a sunny spot with at least 6-8 hours of direct sun daily.
- Avoid low spots where rainwater settles. Lychee roots need oxygen and do not like waterlogging.
- Use a place with good airflow, but protect young trees from strong drying wind.
- For better fruiting in Jamaica, cooler hillsides and areas with a clear dry/cool season are better than very hot lowland spots.
- Do not plant too close to walls, tanks, drains, buildings, or other trees. A mature lychee canopy needs space.

2. Prepare the planting spot

- Clear grass and weeds from a circle about 3-4 feet wide around the planting spot.
- Dig a wide hole, about 2-3 times wider than the root ball. The hole should not be much deeper than the bag/pot.
- Loosen the soil around the hole so new roots can spread outward.
- If the soil is heavy clay or the area gets very wet, plant on a raised mound or raised bed.
- Mix a small amount of compost into the backfill if the soil is poor. Do not put fresh manure directly on the roots.

3. Transplanting steps for air-layered / circumposed lychee

- Plant late afternoon or early evening when the sun is cooler.
- Remove the bag/pot carefully and keep the root ball together. Do not shake off the soil from the roots.
- Plant at the same depth the tree was growing in the bag or pot. Do not bury the trunk or root crown deeper.

- Backfill gently and press the soil just enough to remove large air pockets. Do not compact it hard.
- Water deeply immediately after planting.
- Stake the tree if wind can rock it. Rocking damages new roots and slows establishment.

4. Roots and mulch - do not bury the root crown

- Lychee has many important feeding roots close to the soil surface. Treat the topsoil under the canopy as a protected root zone.
- Feeder roots usually spread outward toward the drip line of the canopy, and established trees may spread roots beyond the canopy edge.
- Some deeper roots may go several feet down where the soil is deep and well drained, but most feeding happens near the surface.
- Use mulch 3-6 inches deep over the root zone to keep the soil cool and moist.
- Keep mulch 6-8 inches away from the trunk. Do not heap soil or mulch against the stem.
- Do not dig, burn, trench, or spray herbicide under the canopy. Avoid weed-whacker damage to the trunk.

5. Watering schedule for Jamaica

Stage	Watering guide
Day of transplanting	Water deeply immediately after planting. The full root ball and surrounding soil should be moist.
First 7 days	Water every day unless rain keeps the soil moist. Morning or late afternoon is best.
Weeks 2-4	In hot dry weather, water 3-5 times per week. Do not let the root ball dry out completely.
Months 2-6	Water 2-3 times weekly in dry weather. Skip watering after good rain. Keep mulch in place.
Established tree	Water during flowering, fruit set, and fruit swelling. During the cool/dry rest before flowering, avoid pushing constant soft new leaf growth.
Best method	Water slowly at the base and under the mulch, not just against the trunk. Deep watering is better than a quick splash.

Simple soil check: Push a finger 2-3 inches into the soil. If it feels dry at that depth, water. If it feels wet or sticky, wait.

6. Soil, drainage, and pH

- Best soil: well-drained loam, sandy loam, or light clay loam with organic matter.
- Avoid swampy, compacted, or constantly wet soil. Waterlogging can cause root decline.
- Soil pH target: about 5.5-6.5. Slightly acidic soil helps lychee take up nutrients.
- Water pH target: about 6.0-7.0; acceptable around 5.5-7.5. Very alkaline water can contribute to yellow leaves over time.
- If leaves become yellow between green veins, check drainage, soil pH, water pH, and micronutrients such as iron, zinc, manganese, magnesium, and boron.

7. Feeding / fertilizer

Stage	Feeding guide
First 4-6 weeks after transplanting	Do not over-fertilize. Let the tree settle. Use water, mulch, and light compost support.
Young tree in active growth	Feed lightly with a balanced fruit-tree fertilizer or compost-based feeding. Small regular feeding is safer than one strong dose.
Before flowering season	Reduce nitrogen. Too much nitrogen can push leaves instead of flowers.

Stage	Feeding guide
Flowering and fruit set	Keep moisture steady. Support with potassium, calcium, magnesium, and trace elements where needed. Avoid harsh sprays during flowering.
After harvest	This is a good time to prune lightly, water, and feed so the tree can make a healthy flush for the next cycle.

Important: A dark green, fast-growing lychee tree is not always a fruiting tree. Too much rich manure or high-nitrogen fertilizer near flowering time can reduce flowering.

8. Pruning, clipping, and size control

- Prune lightly. Lychee does not need heavy cutting every few months.
- Best pruning time is after harvest or after the expected fruiting season, not right before flowering.
- Remove dead, diseased, crossing, or crowded branches.
- Open the center slightly so light and air can enter the canopy.
- Keep the lower skirt from touching the ground.
- For customer-friendly harvesting, keep the tree around 10-15 feet in a home garden or 12-18 feet in a small orchard.
- Avoid heavy pruning just before flowering because you may cut off the mature tips that would have flowered.

9. Conditions that promote fruiting

- **Cool, dry rest:** Lychee needs a cooler, drier period to help trigger flowering. This is the biggest reason some trees grow well but do not bear well.
- **Mature branch tips:** Flowers come from mature terminal shoots. If the tree is constantly flushing young leaves, flowering can be weak.
- **Low nitrogen before flowering:** Too much nitrogen before flowering encourages leaves instead of flowers.
- **Full sun:** A shaded tree may grow, but it usually flowers and fruits less.
- **Pollinators:** Bees and other insects help fruit set. Avoid insecticides during flowering.
- **Steady water during fruiting:** Once flowers and young fruits are present, do not let the tree dry out badly.
- **Good drainage:** Root stress from waterlogging can reduce flowering, fruit set, and tree health.

10. Flowering and fruiting expectations

- Air-layered / circumposed trees generally fruit sooner than seed-grown trees because they come from mature fruiting wood.
- Plan for about 2-5 years after planting for meaningful fruiting under good care, but this can vary by tree size, location, and climate.
- In very hot lowland areas, the tree may need more years or may fruit irregularly because flowering needs a cool/dry signal.
- Do not force a newly transplanted tree to hold a heavy crop too early. First build roots, branches, and canopy strength.
- After flowering, fruit usually takes about 3-4 months to size up and ripen, depending on weather and variety.
- Fruit splitting can happen when the tree is dry and then receives heavy rain. Mulch and steady watering help reduce stress.

11. Simple monthly care routine

Timing	What to do
Every week in dry weather	Check soil moisture under the mulch. Water deeply when the root zone is drying.
Every month	Check mulch, weeds, pests, yellow leaves, and trunk damage. Keep grass away from the root zone.
Active growth periods	Feed lightly. Watch for new flushes and healthy green leaves.

Timing	What to do
Before expected flowering	Reduce nitrogen and avoid heavy pruning. Let the branch tips mature.
Flowering	Protect pollinators. Avoid strong sprays and keep moisture steady.
After harvest	Prune lightly, feed, mulch, and water to prepare the next growth cycle.

12. Common problems and quick checks

Problem	Possible cause and what to check
Tree grows but does not fruit	Too warm all year, no cool/dry rest, too much nitrogen, too much shade, tree too young, or branch tips not mature.
Yellow leaves	Poor drainage, high soil/water pH, root stress, or micronutrient shortage.
Leaf burn after feeding	Fertilizer too strong or placed too close to the roots. Water well and reduce fertilizer strength.
Fruit drop	Drought stress, poor pollination, heavy rain, nutrient imbalance, or weak tree health.
Fruit splitting	Irregular watering, dry spell followed by heavy rain, or variety/weather sensitivity.

Sources used for this guide

- UF/IFAS lychee growing guidance - used for climate, soil, planting, and mature tree size guidance.
- Queensland / Australian lychee production guidance - used for pruning, water management, and flowering context.
- Lychee root-distribution research - used for shallow feeder-root and drip-line root-zone guidance.
- General tropical fruit-tree care experience for Jamaica - used to adapt watering and transplanting steps for local customer use.